

THE FIRST TEN MINUTES

Six questions every owner should be able to answer

None of these are technical. They're the questions I ask first, and you can answer them about your own company tonight. Each one shows you where a decision got made by accident.

☐ **1 Who decides what technology gets bought?**

Not who pays the bill. Who says yes before a new tool, vendor, or contract comes in the door.

Red flag: Whoever had the company card that day. If nobody owns the decision, nobody owns the result.

☐ **2 Who controls the keys?**

The top-level administrator account for your email, and the account that owns your domain name. Not your own password.

Red flag: "I think the IT company has it," or the name of someone who left years ago. Your front door is living on someone else's goodwill.

☐ **3 What's the spreadsheet?**

Watch someone do real work for ten minutes. There's often a spreadsheet doing what the software you pay for doesn't.

Red flag: You didn't know it existed, and it lives on one person's computer.

☐ **4 What are you paying for every month?**

Pull three months of card statements and find every technology charge.

Red flag: Tools nobody remembers buying, two products doing the same job, and seats for people who left.

☐ **5 What one outage stops you from making money, and what's the plan?**

Name the system. Then ask what happens in the first hour it's down, and who makes that call.

Red flag: There isn't a plan, or the plan is "the IT company handles that."

☐ **6 If your most important system had to be replaced next year, how long would it take you to know what you'd lose?**

Know which system it is, who really understands it, what it feeds, how your data gets out, and when the contract renews.

Red flag: "I'd have to ask someone," or "we'd figure it out when we got there."

If you answered all six cleanly, your technology is being run on purpose. If you couldn't, it's being run by accident, one quick choice at a time, and nobody has gone back to decide those choices on purpose.

If one of these made you uncomfortable, good. Now you know where to look.